

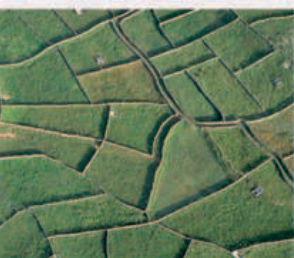


## BEFORE

**Despite advances in farming practices and knowledge, pre-18th-century food production was inefficient and reliant on manual labor.**

## ENCLOSURE

The enclosure system was first developed in England in the 12th century, and saw the division of large, commonly-owned fields into small, privately-owned plots. Laborers were forced from the fields by land owners thanks to a series of Enclosure Acts. This practice spread through Europe during the 19th century.



ENCLOSURE SYSTEM

## NEW METHODS

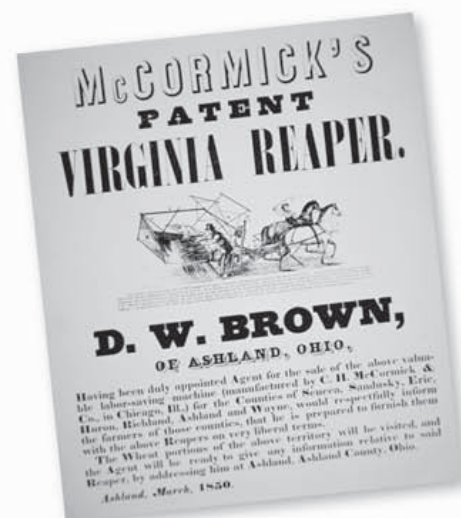
By the mid-17th century many farmers began to treat **farming as a science**. They adopted new winter feeding methods, which made fresh meat available year-round. Improved seeds in Holland and later in England yielded new varieties of fruit and vegetables, and numerous new horse-drawn threshers, cultivators, grain, and grass cutters were used.

## POPULATION GROWTH

In 1750 the world population began to boom. Although this had happened before, each time the population had ceased to grow because agriculture could not feed the extra people. However, by 1750 the onset of agricultural technology allowed this population growth to be sustained.

**T**he mid-18th century witnessed a dramatic increase in world population. The British economist Thomas Malthus (see right) believed that this rise would eventually be halted by a shortage of food. He had not accounted, however, for vast improvements in agricultural practice.

In 1701, Jethro Tull had developed the horse-drawn seed-drill, a machine for efficiently planting seeds, while a four-year system of crop rotation dispensed with the need to replenish fields by leaving them unfarmed for a season. These changes would have been impossible under the old common-field system, but a spate of Enclosure Acts (see BEFORE) during the 19th century allowed landowners to evict peasants from the land, and experiment with new farming techniques without the consent



## Mechanical reaping

Cyrus McCormick's mechanical reaper of 1831 was a boon to wheat farmers in the American Midwest. It could do the work of three men, and was soon exported around the world.

## Changing practices

Rural scene like this one in Norfolk, England in 1887 had remained relatively unchanged for centuries. Eventually, with the introduction of steam power, horse-drawn plows became obsolete.

# The Food Revolution

**The Agricultural Revolution that began in the mid-18th century saw a massive increase in food production. The dramatic increase in efficiency fed a rising population, allowing it to expand further. Workers moved away from the fields and into the factories, providing labor to help drive the Industrial Revolution.**

